

THE TECHBRO DICTIONARY

*A Comprehensive & Definitive Guide to Modern Corporate Jargon,
LinkedIn Vernacular & Startup-Industrial Complex Terminology*

First Edition • 2026 • Peer-Reviewed by Absolutely No One

"We're not just building a dictionary. We're disrupting the lexicographic ecosystem by dogfooding a synergistic, full-stack approach to ideating net-net definitions that move the needle on thought leadership."

A

Align

v.

To schedule a meeting to discuss scheduling another meeting. Often used to describe the act of forcing agreement while maintaining the illusion of collaboration.

"We need to align on the alignment of our alignment strategy before EOD."

B

Bandwidth

n.

The polite way of saying "absolutely not." A finite and perpetually depleted resource that exists solely to decline requests.

"I'd love to help, but I just don't have the bandwidth right now." (Translation: I would not love to help.)

C

Circle Back

v.

To indefinitely postpone something while creating the comforting illusion of future action. The corporate equivalent of "I'll call you."

"Let's circle back on this next quarter." (Narrator: They did not circle back.)

D

Deep Dive

n.

A longer meeting. Distinguished from a regular meeting only by the presence of the phrase "deep dive" in the calendar invite.

"I'd love to do a deep dive on our Q3 engagement metrics." (Duration: 90 minutes. Depth achieved: wading pool.)

Disrupt

v.

To copy something that already exists, put it in an app, and add a subscription model. Bonus points if the thing you're disrupting was working fine.

"We're disrupting the toaster industry with an AI-powered, blockchain-enabled smart bread experience."

Dogfooding

v.

Using your own product, but describing it with terminology that makes it sound unpleasant. Somehow became a badge of honor rather than a health code violation.

"We've been dogfooding the new release internally and honestly it's been... a journey."

Double Down

v.

To do the same thing that isn't working, but with more conviction and a bigger slide deck.

"The rebrand didn't move the needle, so we're going to double down on the rebrand of the rebrand."

E

Ecosystem

n.

A collection of loosely related products, services, and APIs that technically interoperate in the same way that a toaster and a bathtub technically interoperate.

"Our ecosystem of tools empowers developers to seamlessly integrate with our other tools that also need integrating."

F

Full-Stack

adj.

Describes a developer who is mass-produced by 12-week bootcamps and has watched at least three YouTube tutorials on both frontend and backend development.

"I'm a full-stack engineer." (Has deployed one Express server and a React todo app.)

G

Growth Hacking

n.

Marketing, but described using language that makes it sound like you're breaking into a mainframe rather than A/B testing button colors.

"Our growth hacking strategy leveraged viral loop mechanics to 10x our sign-up funnel." (They changed the button from gray to green.)

I

Ideate

v.

To think, but in a way that justifies a whiteboard, Post-it notes, and a \$400/hour facilitator.

"Let's ideate on some blue-sky solutions in our innovation sandbox." (Translation: Let's brainstorm.)

L

Lean In

v.

To do significantly more work while being told it's empowering. Often invoked by people who are already standing.

"I really need you to lean in on this initiative." (The initiative has no budget, no timeline, and no executive sponsor.)

Leverage

v.

To use. That's it. That's the whole definition. But "use" only has three letters and doesn't look as good on a slide.

"We need to leverage our core competencies to leverage our leverage." (Use our skills to use our stuff.)

M

Move the Needle

v.

To produce a result that is measurable, visible, and will look good in someone else's performance review.

"Is this really going to move the needle?" (Is this going to make me look good to my boss's boss?)

N

Net-Net

n., adv.

"In summary," but for people who believe that saying a word twice makes it more executive.

"So net-net, the net-net is that we need to net-net this by Friday."

North Star

n.

A guiding metric or vision that the entire company aligns around for approximately two quarters before it is quietly replaced by a different North Star.

"Our North Star is user delight." (Last quarter's North Star, revenue growth, has been sent to a farm upstate.)

O

Operationalize

v.

To actually do the thing everyone has been talking about doing for six months. The rarest verb in the techbro lexicon.

"It's time to operationalize our strategy." (It has been time for four sprints.)

P

Pivot

v., n.

To abandon your original idea after burning through most of your Series A, but describe it using the language of basketball rather than failure.

"We're not failing, we're pivoting to an adjacent market opportunity." (The original market opportunity filed a restraining order.)

S

Scale

v.

To make something bigger. The word exists primarily to distinguish startups (which "scale") from regular businesses (which "grow" like peasants).

"We need to think about how this scales." (We have 11 users but are architecting for 11 million.)

Ship It

v.

To release software to production with the confidence of someone who has never been paged at 3 AM. Often accompanied by a Slack emoji.

"We're just going to ship it and iterate." (The QA team has entered the chat. The QA team has left the chat.)

Synergy

n.

The original techbro word. A mystical force that allegedly emerges when two things are combined, even though no one has ever successfully measured it.

"The synergy between our sales and engineering teams is incredible." (Sales and engineering have not spoken since the Q2 incident.)

T

Table Stakes

n.

The bare minimum, repackaged to sound like a poker metaphor so that doing the bare minimum sounds strategic.

"SSO is table stakes at this point." (We still don't have SSO.)

Take This Offline

v. phrase

To end a meeting argument by scheduling a smaller, more intense argument. A diplomatic ejector seat.

"Great points, both of you. Let's take this offline." (Translation: You are both embarrassing yourselves.)

Thought Leader

n.

A person with a LinkedIn account, a ring light, and opinions. Distinguished from regular people with opinions by a blue checkmark and/or a TEDx talk.

"As a thought leader in the DevOps space, I believe we need to shift left." (Has mass-produced 47 LinkedIn posts this week.)

Tiger Team

n.

A small group of people doing the work that the larger group was supposed to be doing. Essentially an admission that the org chart is decorative.

"We're spinning up a tiger team to address the outage." (The tiger team is just Dave. Dave is always the tiger team.)

U

Unpack

v.

To discuss, but in a way that suggests the topic arrived in luggage and requires careful handling by trained professionals.

"There's a lot to unpack here." (There isn't. The answer is no.)

V

Value-Add

n., adj.

Something useful, described in a way that implies usefulness is exceptional rather than the baseline expectation for doing your job.

"What's the value-add of this meeting?" (This meeting has no value-add. No meeting has ever had a value-add.)